Brockwell Lido sink or swim? What does the future hold for the Herne Hill landmark?

Lambeth Council say they'll take over - but can they turn things around?

by **News Desk** — 18th April 2026 in **News+** 0

Brockwell Lido (c) google street view

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For its swimmers and gym goers Brockwell Lido is a sanctuary in the heart of South London, but the beloved Grade II-listed leisure site now faces what could be its biggest test yet, as its operator, Fusion Lifestyle, goes bust, ***writes Liv Facey and Alex Levy…***

After what campaigners and local MP Helen Hayes say amounts to years of 'underinvestment', can Lambeth Council turn things around for the Art Deco icon?

And where will it find the 'millions' needed to bring the facilities up to scratch?

On April 1st, after mounting uncertainty, Lambeth Council announced it will take over running Brockwell Lido, including the cafe and gym, on the same day Fusion Lifestyle called in administrators.

The lido's facilities are expected to remain open until fully transferred to Lambeth Council's inhouse gym operator – Active Lambeth – from July 1.

The local authority says its priority is to "maintain continuity of service, protect public access to the site and secure the long-term future of Brockwell Lido for residents".

In a statement to this paper, Nadeem Sweiss, director at S&W and joint administrator of Fusion, said: "We know how important the lido is to the communities that it serves, and we are committed to supporting a smooth transition.

"We understand Active Lambeth have some ambitious plans to update the Lido and we will continue to work collaboratively with management and Lambeth Council to limit disruption and safeguard the long-term future of the lido."

Speculation had been mounting for months over the state of Fusion's finances. The operator, a charity which had recently celebrated its 25th anniversary, was reported not to have filed its accounts since 31 December 2022, when it had a reported turnover of £50.8 million.

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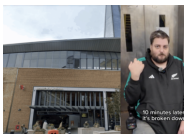

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In August 2025 it was reported that Fusion owed management fees of £166,038 to Bedford Borough Council, for whom it operated three leisure sites; debts which have now been repaid in full.

Fusion had operated a network of 25 facilities across the country, including two in London; Golden Lane and Brockwell Lido. All its leisure centres will remain open except Golden Lane, which is set to close awaiting refurbishment.

Fusion also has, in the recent past, run other council leisure centres across South London. It held Southwark's leisure contract for years, before losing it in a major retender. In Lewisham, Fusion partnered with the council and helped it open the £20m Glass Mill Leisure Centre in 2013, but was later dropped by the borough in 2020.

Before news broke of the collapse, Brockwell Lido Users (BLU) – the official group representing all users of the lido – held an Extraordinary General Meeting on March 22 to address public frustration over the lido's future.

At the meeting, Dulwich and West Norwood MP Helen Hayes told attendees, in no uncertain terms, that Fusion had descended "into a state of crisis over effectively poor financial management. I think, taking on too many sites all across the country and getting into difficulties is really a very, very sad and quite shocking state of affairs".

Her comments were reminiscent of those delivered in parliament last month, during a debate she dubbed 'for the love of Lidos'. Addressing the house, Hayes had said closure and reopening is part of a longer story of precariousness for public baths and lidos across the country, and paid tribute to BLU's work, while also sharing that she had swum regularly at the lido since 1996 and and once fainted in the changing rooms after a "balmy 8 degree" dip.

Helen Hayes MP (House of Commons)

At the EGM, Lambeth cabinet lead Cllr Donatus Anyanwu, said the local authority was prepared to step in immediately, telling attendees: “The council will not allow the lido to cease.

“Whatever happens after that is a decision that the council, as a democratically-led institution, will have to make. Continuity of service, protecting the service, is absolutely crucial”.

Lambeth Labour councillor Donatus Anyanwu. Photo from Lambeth Council

The situation has reignited memories of previous threats to the lido's survival. Lambeth shut the lido in 1990 as part of cost-saving measures but reopened it in 1994 after a grassroots campaign and a petition signed by thousands.

After the Lido was brought back into use in the 1990s, Fusion then won a 25 year contract from Lambeth Council in 2003 to redevelop and run the site until May 2031. Over the next four years a gym, spa and fitness studios were built, and the site reopened in October 2007.

BLU chair Ben Longman said that while "in the early days, Fusion did a really good job," and brought "a kind of new era" and "rebirth" to the site, over time investment and regular maintenance fell away.

Over a busy bank holiday weekend, we spoke to many lido users, who painted a consistent picture. The pool is loved, but the facilities feel tired, with much of the equipment not working.

Regular user Adam said: “Fusion has stopped investing in it, so things were breaking and not being fixed.”

“It enhances my life living in London by 80 percent,” said Claire Jones, who swims twice a week describing it as something close to “near prayer.” But Jones claims Fusion made a lot of money from the Lido but “drained” it to other sites rather than reinvesting it.

Her thoughts were echoed by Phillipa, who has used Brockwell Lido for more than a decade after previously going to Tooting Bec Lido. She said there are great things about it but argued Fusion “needed” to go into administration because “things were neglected for too long.”

She claimed the whirlpool “never has been working for about three years,” while the steam room is “always broken”.

Local resident Lesley Hill said Brockwell Lido used to be “a great space” but “pretty pricey” and “not the most welcoming”.

Year-long member Stefan, visiting with friend Molly, was more blunt: “It’s awful.” The jacuzzi, he said, “never worked since I’ve been here.”

Lido users Molly & Stefan

In one of the more obvious signs of deterioration, when our reporter visited, the automatic door button for disabled users was broken, but there were no signs and no information on the website to make any visitors aware.

In the Commons, Hayes has highlighted a change in leadership at Fusion, and the ongoing impact of the pandemic – now half a decade on – as factors in a lack of maintenance and investment.

When asked about the site's future, the BLU were optimistic given that Lambeth had agreed to keep the site open, with Longman telling us: If an under-maintained site closes, it can be much harder to reopen it than to keep it operating."

But is it a takeover that buys time – but not certainty? There is still much that is yet to be thrashed out, and it remains unclear how Lambeth's own financial position could impact running the site.

The lido's listed status is part of what makes it distinctive. It is also part of what makes it expensive. The BLU told us that when the local authority surveys the building and plant, they predict the repair bill could be "well north of a million pounds".

But given the popularity of the venue – and the boom in cold water swimming throughout the year – if Brockwell Lido can't turn a healthy profit, where can?

The lido in winter. Brockwell Park, Herne Hill

Fundraisers jumping into Brockwell Lido

Reitree, Mary, who uses the site every day, told us: “Particularly in the summer they must be raking in. So why are the saunas broken and the showers and the changing room so bad? It’s usable.”

In Parliament, Hayes told MPs she understood Brockwell Lido to be profitable, but that there had been “little transparency about” the income it generates, and “no ringfencing” to

ensure money is spent on the maintenance and investment the site needs.

A lack of transparency is exactly what worries the regulars who spoke with us, and said they fear the centre's profits will not be put back into repairs.

Just before Lambeth Council's takeover, the BLU announced that it had become a charity with the support of Hayes. Charity status gives the group access to grant funding and tax benefits such as Gift Aid.

As they awaited their first formal meeting with the council as the lido's new operators, they told us their main priority is securing the Lido as an accessible, community-centred asset.

"Brockwell Lido is not just a leisure centre," the BLU chair highlighted. "It requires a degree of specificity and agility to run it." He confirmed the group is also pushing for a reset on pricing.

"We have a once in a generation chance to reset the community's relationship with Brockwell Lido," he added, warning against "business as usual."

Among the residents we interviewed for this article, several highlighted the cost, with one resident – Lesley Hill – telling us that being only able to afford membership to one centre, and in her case Brixton Rec had won out.

The future of Brockwell Lido is now being decided in real time, in council offices, in user meetings, and in everyday conversations within the building.

During our visit, we met Alex and Dan, making their first ever trip to the Lido to take advantage of a free trial. Given the recent developments, they said they had quickly found themselves chatting to another user about how the building is run and what the new operators might mean for the future.

"It could definitely do with doing up a little bit, but it's not horrendous," Dan mused. "We were just saying to each other if someone could buy it out and do it up, it would be amazing."

Whether Lambeth's takeover becomes a simple rescue or the start of a different future will depend on what happens after July 1.

But for regular swimmers and gym-goers, the priority is simple. They want the basics fixed. They want a future that feels fair and reflective of this much loved site. One where the lido's profits are transparent, its repairs are funded, and the place that so many Londoners call a sanctuary is run for the community that keeps it alive.

"It's like one of my favourite places in London," cyclist Efah told us "My little sanctuary."

Lambeth Council were approached for comment.

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